Gonzalo Liñán Aldana

Gameplay Programmer / Technical Designer
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Open to remote and relocation | EU work authorisation

SUMMARY

Gameplay programmer and technical designer specialising in combat systems and enemy AI, with a shipped commercial title on PC and console. Owned the combat pillar of The 9th Dragon (Headup Games) end to end in Unreal Engine 5, from player mechanics and game feel to Behavior Tree architecture and balancing. Strong C++ background with hands-on Gameplay Ability System, Perception Systems and Behavior Tree experience, plus Unity and C#. Comfortable working to publisher milestone feedback and architecting systems that designers can configure without code.

EXPERIENCE

Gameplay Programmer / Combat Designer

FrameOver (Freelance) — The 9th Dragon, published by Headup Games | Unreal Engine 5 | May 2026 – September 2026

Beat-'em-up action title for PC, PlayStation 5, Xbox Series X|S and Nintendo Switch. Owned the combat pillar through final production, delivering against publisher milestone feedback. 115 commits across 567 files; 124 tracked production tasks.

- Rebuilt the core combat loop: combo system with input buffering, parry mechanic with unique counterattacks, finisher system gated on enemy state, and stamina and vulnerability states.
- Designed a data-driven ranged-combat architecture in which weapon parameters drive enemy behaviour, with a proxy Behavior Tree switching enemies between melee and ranged based on distance and ammunition.
- Refactored the enemy Behavior Tree architecture for modularity and centralised subclass logic into a modular enemy base, allowing any enemy to use any weapon from data tables rather than code; authored behaviour trees for eight enemy types plus bosses.
- Delivered the game feel layer: hit-stop on combo enders, camera shake scaled to move strength, slow-motion on finisher impact, and variable knockback with chain damage between enemies.
- Built a reusable modular spatial detection system (multi-sphere) resolving player, enemy and level geometry across combat logic.
- Tuned time-to-kill per enemy type and per level via centralised data tables, producing a progressive difficulty curve.
- Built the full tutorial system (15+ tutorials with input validation and completion gating), collectible-driven combo progression, combat UI/HUD, and combat audio implementation.
- Ran combat QA and owned backlog creation, triage and prioritisation for the combat area.

AI Programmer & Combat Designer

Ghunter — Tiny Tavern | Top-Down Action-Adventure, Unreal Engine 5 | Best University Indie Project, BIG Bilbao | January 2024 – November 2024

- Developed an AI framework producing enemy variations through a custom Library Ability Task, building modular Gameplay Abilities combined with Perception Systems and Behavior Trees for a designer-friendly workflow.
- Iterated combat difficulty from structured playtesting feedback, adjusting enemy behaviours, timing windows and stat scaling.
- Authored level blueprints and encounter breakdowns covering pacing, enemy placement, risk-reward zones and combat flow.

PROJECTS

Third-Person Action Multiplayer — Solo Project

Unreal Engine 5, C++ | June 2025 – Present

- Architected a modular combat system using the Gameplay Ability System (GAS) in C++, exposing flexible parameters to Blueprints for a data-driven designer workflow.
- Engineered an event-driven framework using Gameplay Tags to synchronise animation-driven attacks with context-sensitive reactions.
- Implemented dynamic environment systems via World Partition and Chaos Destruction for real-time level changes reacting to player actions and physics forces.

Third-Person Action — Solo Project

Unity 6, C# | November 2024 – June 2025

- Architected a modular Finite State Machine for enemy AI.
- Reduced memory usage and garbage collection spikes with a custom Object Pooling system.
- Created custom inspector tools for rapid level design and enemy attribute balancing via ScriptableObjects.
- Authored the full Game Design Document, defining pillars, progression, difficulty curve and player engagement systems.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages: C++, C#, Java

Engines & Frameworks: Unreal Engine 5 (Gameplay Ability System, Behavior Trees, Perception System, Niagara, Animation Blueprints, Motion Warping, World Partition, Chaos Destruction, Common UI), Unity (DOTS)

Practices: Data-driven architecture, combat design, game feel, encounter and difficulty tuning, performance optimisation, technical documentation, QA and bug triage

Tools: Git, GitHub, GitLab, Fork, Perforce, Docker, Jira, Trello, Notion, Miro

Methodologies: Scrum, Kanban, Agile

Languages spoken: Spanish (native), English (C1)

EDUCATION

Master's Degree in Programming
U-TAD, Madrid | October 2023 – November 2024

Programming with Graphic Engine: Unity
RENDR, Seville | November 2024 – June 2025

Multi-Platform Applications Development
CEU San Pablo, Seville | September 2021 – June 2023